Get access to the staging database

What this guide helps with

Use this guide when a new employee needs read-only access to the staging database for development, testing, or troubleshooting.

This guide explains how to:

- Submit a staging database access request
- Select the correct access role
- Identify the correct approver
- Connect through the company VPN
- Verify that the database connection works

Production database access is not covered by this guide. Production access requires a separate security review and approval.

Before you start

Make sure you have:

- An active company account

- Access to the internal Access Request Portal

- The name of the project or service that requires database access

- The name of your manager or project owner

- The company VPN client installed on your computer

- An approved database client, such as DBeaver, DataGrip, or the company-standard SQL client

Request staging database access

1. Open the internal **Access Request Portal** from the company tools page.

2. Select **New access request**.

3. Choose **Database access** as the request type.

4. Select **Staging** as the environment.

5. Choose the **Read-only** role unless your manager has approved a different role.

6. Enter the project name or service that requires access.

7. Explain why you need access, for example: "I need read-only access to investigate the staging environment for the onboarding dashboard.: "

8. Enter the date when access is needed.

9. Select the project data owner as the approver.

10. Review the request details.

11. Submit the request.

12. Wait for the approval notification before trying to connect.

Find the correct approver

The approver should normally be the data owner for the project or service.

If you cannot find the data owner:

1. Check the project documentation.

2. Ask your manager or technical lead.

3. Contact the Data Platform team in the internal support channel.

4. Do not select a random approver just to submit the request.

Connect to the staging database

After the request has been approved:

1. Connect to the company VPN.

2. Open the Access Request Portal.

3. Open your approved database access request.

4. Copy the staging connection details.

5. Open the approved database client.

6. Create a new connection using the staging host and port.

7. Enter the username supplied by the access portal.

8. Use the approved authentication method.

9. Save the connection using a clear name, such as `Staging - Project Name`.

10. Connect to the staging database.

Do not copy staging credentials into source code, chat messages, screenshots, or public documents.

Verify the connection

After connecting, run a safe read-only query:

```sql
SELECT 1;
```

If the query returns `1`, the connection is working.

You can then confirm that you can access the expected schema:

```sql
SELECT current_database();
```

Only run read-only queries unless a separate request explicitly grants write access.

If access is denied

Check the following:

1. You are connected to the company VPN.
2. The request was approved for the ****Staging**** environment.
3. You selected the correct project and data owner.
4. You are using the ****Read-only**** role credentials.
5. The staging host and port match the details in the approved request.
6. Your database client is using the required authentication method.
7. Your access request has not expired.

If the problem continues:

1. Copy the exact error message.
2. Record the request ID from the Access Request Portal.
3. Contact the Data Platform team.
4. Do not retry using production credentials.
5. Do not disable VPN or security controls to work around the error.

Common errors

Authentication failed

Your credentials may be incorrect, expired, or assigned to the wrong environment. Recheck the approved request and request a credential reset if necessary.

Connection timed out

Check that you are connected to the company VPN and that the staging host and port are correct.

Permission denied

Your account may not have the required role. Confirm that the request was approved and that you are using the correct database user.

Database does not exist

Check that you selected the correct staging project and copied the database name exactly as shown in the access portal.

Security reminders

- Never use production credentials for a staging connection.
- Never share database passwords in chat or email.
- Never commit credentials, connection strings, or secrets to Git.
- Use read-only access unless write access is explicitly approved.
- Close the database client when you finish.
- Report suspected credential exposure to the security team immediately.